

# Anatomy of the **VERDICT**

It was a decisive vote from an impatient India that expects more than state patronage. The new regime can't take refuge in populism any longer.

| By Anirudha Dutta |

**C**lichéd as it may sound, the big winner of General Elections 2009 is the common man for having delivered a verdict that will not give the Congress any excuses for non-performance now. The biggest issue in what was dubbed an issueless election was the fractured nature of the Indian polity and that issue has been addressed at least for the next five years. Particularly significant is the defeat of the Left, which had successfully perpetrated the myth that the 2004 verdict was one against reforms. Half-lies and half-truths have been developed into a fine art by Communists the world over and our own comrades are no exception. As a result, the UPA government failed to deliver on economic reforms that the Congress had promised in its manifesto, although its own ministers in important portfolios like education and home did nothing and did more harm than good.

However, the defeat of the Left, sweet as it is, may be for the wrong reasons. While Mamata Banerjee's three-

decade campaign against the Left has finally made a big dent in the Marxist bastion, for West Bengal the loss of the Nano project can only be incalculable. We all know what Banerjee opposes, but what is her vision?

## THE POLITICS OF ASPIRATION

For the next five years, the Congress will not have to lead a government that is constantly hamstrung by its partners. After the 2004 elections, Dr Manmohan Singh had announced that his government would improve on the delivery of the government and governance. Instead, it took refuge in increasing populist schemes, which could be funded thanks to a booming economy led not so much by the UPA government's policies but the fruits of the policies of the previous five years and a synchronised boom in global economy. With growth slowing down, the government's finances are now under pressure.